

Chapter 3

Development and Aims of Comparative Education

Commonness and Differences of Factors Involved

To-day the various countries of the world are interdependent. An event in one part of the world has its natural and inevitable impact in the other areas of the globe. This is true not only of epidemics, earthquakes, wars, famines, floods, etc., but also of educational systems. In other words, the educational system of one country positively or negatively influences the educational organisations and systems of others. It is because of this that we have been stimulated to make a comparative study of the different systems of education as obtained in various countries. From this study, we have come to realise that the various educational systems prevailing in the different parts of the world have certain common factors and certain differences.

Comparative Study in Early Stages

Marc-Antoine Jullien de Paris began the study of comparative education in 1817. In this study, he emphasized the analysis of the common and different factors found in the various educational systems of the world. He wanted to give a scientific approach to education. So he detested the idea that education should be limited to narrow ideas of the ruler of a

country. Therefore, he analysed the principles and conclusions of the various educational systems in a tabular form. He believed that by tabulation he would be able to elucidate some principles and rules regarding the educational systems concerned. Thus he emphasized the study of comparative education. However, few were aware of his views regarding this method before the twentieth century.

We have to note that comparative education did not begin with this kind of analysis. In the beginning of the twentieth century, many travellers in their accounts have included descriptions of educational systems of the lands they visited. These travellers also hinted at the social progress and economic prosperity of countries of their visits, and in this connection they emphasized the importance of the educational systems of the lands concerned. They contended that educational systems were responsible for the social progress and economic prosperity of the people concerned. Thus travellers' accounts of educational systems have occupied an important place in the study of comparative education.

Development of Comparative Education

We find three stages in the development of comparative education.

① The First Stage:

The first stage in the development of comparative education begins with the ideas propounded by Antoine Jullien. This stage continued upto the beginning of the twentieth century. During the nineteenth century, the belief had gained ground that the characteristics prevailing in one country may be absorbed in the educational system of another. This belief resulted into the collection of data on education of other countries. These data were arranged in tables and an attempt was made to deduce some general principles from the same. Consequently, people began to believe that the educational system in a country may be organised according to these principles. But in the collection of the above data no attention

was paid to social, political, economic and religious conditions of the country studied, although they have a direct influence on its educational system. Therefore, it was not considered necessary whether the country whose educational pattern was to be copied has the same cultural, social, political, economic and religious traditions as the other country had. In this first stage of development of comparative education, the names of Victor Cousin of France, Matthew Arnold of England, Horace Man and Henry Bernard of U.S.A., Tolstoy and Ushinsky of Russia and Domingo Sarmiento of Argentina may be specially mentioned. These persons and their followers have opined that in the development of education of a country, it is necessary to study the educational systems of other countries. Thus the study of comparative education began in order to enrich the educational system of one's own country.

② The Second Stage:

In the second stage, social, economic and other circumstances which influence education in a country were studied. Thus the influence of these factors in the context of educational development was specially noted and to what extent these factors were suitable for another country. So the tendency of blind imitation was discarded. Sir Michael Sadler of England was the father of this second stage. In 1907 he published an essay in which he emphasized the point that educational system of a country was related to the social environment of the land. Sadler's point of view was accepted by Issac Kandal and Robert Ulich of U.S.A., Friedrich Schneider of Germany, Joseph Lauwerys and Nicholas Hans of England.

③ The Third Stage:

The third stage starts in 1950. Bereday, George Z.F. regards this stage as a period of analysis. In this method, economic political, social and religious factors were analysed. Then it was inferred up to what extent that educational system was suitable or unsuitable for another country. Thus the related

factors of education were specially studied. Therefore, in the third stage, an attempt was made to reach a conclusion on the basis of various factors, whereas in the second stage this tendency was absent.

✓ Robert Ulich, Friedrich Schneider and Issac Kandel have contributed significantly to the development of the third stage of the study of comparative education.

The Meaning and Aim of Comparative Education

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Definition } We have seen that Antoine Jullien started the study of comparative education. But now the scope of comparative education has been further enlarged. Within comparative education, we now make an analysis of educational systems of various countries in order to understand their educational problems with a view to find out solutions of one's own educational problems. In this attempt, we also try to understand the philosophical background of the country concerned, as the same influences the educational system. There are certain foundations of education which are universal. When we talk of the philosophical background, it implies that we have to make a study of the same impartially. We have already noted that political, cultural, social, religious and economic conditions influence the educational system of a country. Therefore, the purpose of the study of comparative education is also to study the conditions and factors that influence education in a land for then alone we may succeed in finding out solutions of educational problems.

- ② The purpose of the study of comparative education is also to study those differences that make the education of a country different from that of another. In studying these differences, we also study the causative factors of the same. We study the differences in the social, political, economic and religious situations which make various systems of education different from each other. However, let us not infer that the purpose of comparative education is to study the inherent differences in various educational systems. The purpose is to study those general principles on which development of education in any
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country is based. Thus comparative education highlights the universality of general principles in the existing differences. Needless to say that comparative education aims at strengthening international unity by drawing our attention to the universal general principles.

The purpose of comparative education is also to understand why the educational systems of some countries are progressive and of others, backward. The administrative system of the land influences the state of the educational system. For example, the administrative machineries of Switzerland, Canada, U.S.A. and Japan are combined with local autonomy and decentralised control. Consequently, in the educational systems of these countries, we find a reflection of their political philosophy. Thus political philosophy and the administrative systems of various countries determine the administration and control of education. The purpose of comparative education is also to study these elements in their proper perspectives.

We have to keep in mind that besides an analytical approach, synthesis is also emphasized in the study of comparative education. In this synthesis an attempt is made to understand how a social structure and political philosophy have influenced education. Thus, in comparative education we try to include the study of all these factors. Herein we study the impact of both formal and informal education. Consequently, we have included sociological basis of education as well; i.e., we study the place of social process, social control, social organisation and social change in the development of education of a country. Evidently, the scope of comparative education has become very comprehensive now.

SUMMARY

The similarities and differences of factors in the study of comparative education.

The Beginning of Comparative Education: By Antoine Jullien the analysis of similar and dis-similar factors. Traveller's accounts. Attention on social and economic tendencies.

The Development of the Study of Comparative Education:

Stage I: Antoine Jullien's ideas, Imitation.

Stage II: Study of the social, political and economic conditions.

Stage III: The period of analysis of social, political, religious and other factors. The universal principles, aiming at international unity.

The Meaning and Purpose of Comparative Education: To bring in reform in one's own educational system. To study educational problems and their solutions. The study of philosophical, social, economic, political and religious conditions. The study of differences. The study of general principles. The idea of international unity. The study of causes of progressiveness and backwardness of education. The study of sociological foundations of education.

EXERCISES

1. Trace the various stages of development of the study of comparative education.
2. Discuss the meaning scope and purpose of comparative education.